

**How has Hindi cinema across decades reflected and shaped the
shifting social choices on issues like feminism, environmentalism
and nationalism?**

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Abstract:

Bollywood is a household name in India, more so in the Hindi speaking belt where everything in people's lives finds a reflection in cinema. It parallels reality; exaggerating it, critiquing it and sometimes just showing it as it is. Since cinema is made for the people and is basically run by their viewership and interest in it, it is possible to trace the trajectory of a society through its cinema. For instance, seeing a woman smoke a cigarette on screen in 2025 would garner much less whispers and sounds from the theatre audience than in 1940. This is because with each passing decade, society's sensibilities change, enhance and adapt to the concurrent social practices. There has also been a monumental shift in how film makers depict socio-political advancements and how the audience receives them. Moreover, newer and more creative styles of film making and story telling have emerged. This paper will study some representative films made in the 12 decades from 1910s to 2020s from the lens of nationalism, feminism, feudalism and environmentalism and will trace the development of national sensibilities through them.

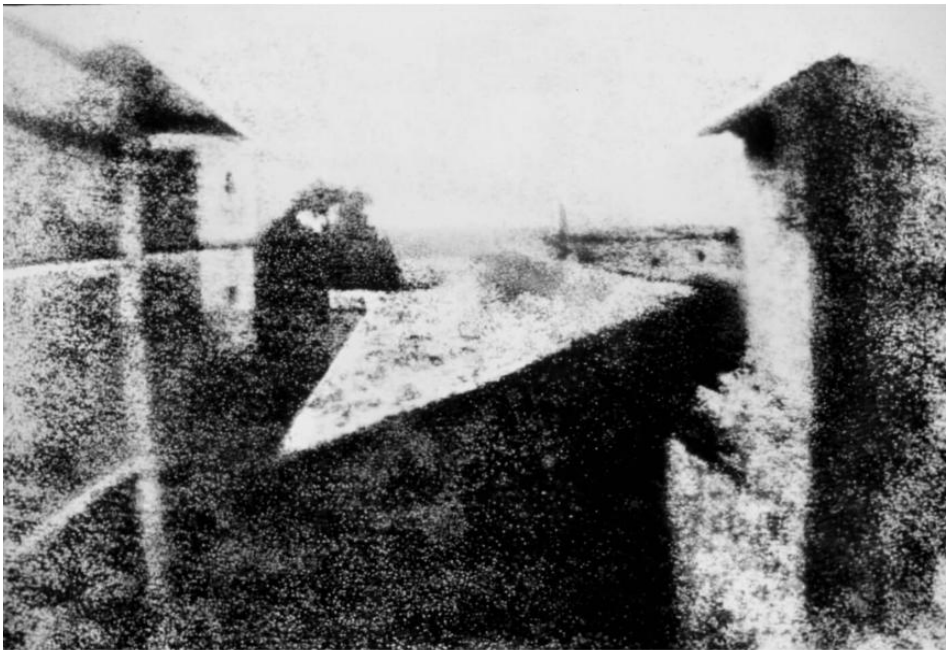
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A Brief History of the origin of Cinema and Hindi Cinema

“Cinema is the mirror of society.”

It is not possible to assign the above-mentioned quote to an individual but it can be safely said that anyone who knows about cinema can understand the quote. What started off in 19th century France with the creation of the first photograph titled ‘View from the windows at Le

Gras' generated by channeling light through camera obscura into a pewter block coated with bitumen and was taken forward by an Englishman who created the first 'motion picture' titled 'The horse in motion' by basically 'tricking' the eyes of the viewers by taking images and projecting them fast enough to appear as if they're moving has today deepened its roots around the world, gaining immense popularity.



View from the Window at Le Gras (1825) by Nicéphore Niépce

(Heckmann, 2025)

What started there led to the making of first short, silent films, sometimes being just two seconds like the 'Roundhay Garden Scene' made in 1888 by a Frenchman, Louis Le Prince. Some other films that are considered important from this era are 'A Trip to the Moon', a landmark French film from 1902 and 'The Great Train Robbery', a 1903 American film (Heckmann, 2025).

It was after a few years to this that experiments with sound were added to this still quite new art of filmmaking, owing to new technological advancements. This was a landmark event which played a crucial role in revolutionizing this new found art of film-making for an eternity and adding new dimensions to it. Like first films, the first effort to incorporate sounds and motion pictures was also seen in France, with the first known public exhibition of a projected sound film taking place in Paris, 1900. This exhibit used the ‘Phono-Cinéma-Théâtre’ system, where sounds were recorded on a phonograph and the speed of the film projector was adjusted to match the sound. This was however not an overnight success and another effort was made by famous inventor, Thomas Alva Edison who in 1893, experimented with a phonograph record to synchronize sounds with his kinetoscope films. This effort was showcased in 1894 through the Dickinson experimental sound film, which is considered a milestone in Cinema History. It featured William K.L Dickson playing a violin into a recording horn for an off-camera wax cylinder (DeGuzman, 2024).

The watershed achievement of being the first feature film to incorporate sound belongs to ‘Don Juan’, made in 1926.¹ ‘Don Juan’ featured a synchronized musical score and sound effects produced using the Vitaphone system. Even though ‘Don Juan’ can be considered a pioneer in films released with sound, it was with the release of ‘The Jazz Singer’ in 1927 that ‘talkies’ came to existence, added dialogues with sound and changed the landscape of movie making forever (DeGuzman, 2024). This critical moment in film making gave birth to many new and related industries like film music singing and directing, playback singing, introduction of musical orchestras and made cinema a more immersive experience.

¹ It is noteworthy here that a simple and layman distinction between a film and a feature film is that while a film can be used as a generic term for any motion picture of unspecified length, a feature film is usually more complex in narrative and usually intended for a theatrical release

In the context of the Hindi film industry (more popularly known as ‘Bollywood’), the advent of film making was later than the west but caught with the pace and figures soon enough. The accolade of being the first Indian and Bollywood film resides with ‘*Raja Harishchandra*’ (1913). Directed by Dada Sahab Phalke, often referred to as the ‘Father of Indian cinema’, this 40 minutes long film began what was to become Bollywood in coming years. It is said that Phalke was inspired to create his magnum opus when he got awe-struck by a French film ‘*The Life of Christ*’ (1903), twice in a day. He reportedly left his job and went to London to study this new found passion. Upon returning, he put his life and soul into realizing his dream. His wife sold her jewelry and he had to cast men for women’s roles too because of the unwillingness of women to participate (PDR, 2016). Dada Sahab Phalke himself advertised his craft as “*Raja Harishchandra*. A performance with 57,000 photographs. A picture two miles long. All for only three annas” (Choudhury, 2023). The film had both Hindi and English intertitles and was created in a film of 3700 feet, of which unfortunately only 1475 feet survives (PDR, 2015). The film, however, did not perform at the Box office as great as probably Phalke would have expected. It sold only 75 tickets in the first 5 shows. Although this first endeavour in Indian cinema was appreciated critically by many people who watched it, earning hefty money from it could not be the case for Phalke (Townparle, 2018). Safe to say, back then, neither the audience nor even the director or the cast members had the slightest hint about the movement they had kick-started in the field of Indian visual arts; a revolution began knocking at the door.²

² It is important to note here that some opinions hold that although *Raja Harishchandra* spearheaded the advent of Bollywood, it was essentially a Marathi film due to the majority of its cast and crew being from Maharashtra. This would also possibly make the movie the first Indian non Bollywood film. However one chooses to see it, it is a rather undeniable fact that Phalke’s masterpiece posits itself as a cornerstone in Hindi cinema nonetheless.

The story of the first Indian film with sound in it was no less dramatic than the one discussed above. What started with the director Ardeshir Irani winning a 14,000 rupees lottery gave Irani an impetus to dream beyond his humble beginnings and give Bollywood its first ‘talkies’, ‘*Alam Ara*’ (1931). Irani was the first to take the daring leap into the then newly developing sound industry. The medium of language was Hindustani (a blend of Hindi and Urdu) to reach wider mass and it worked out because the film was a critical and commercial success. The film also experimented with costumes, sets and microphones, without potentially knowing that it was laying up the foundation of a billion dollar industry. Interestingly, ‘*Alam Ara*’ was also the first film with the playback songs. One of the songs was ‘*De De Khuda ke Naam Par*’ which was sung by a watchman who worked nearby. Unfortunately for cinema lovers and historians, no surviving copy of the film remains today but its impact is far from being unnoticed (Shah, 2023).

Another landmark film in Hindi cinema was ‘*Kisan Kanya*’ (1937). The film brought colours to Bollywood, literally and figuratively by using the cinecolour technology imported then from Germany. The film was directed by Moti B. Gidwani, produced by Ardeshir Irani (the director of *Alam Ara*) and showcased the plight of poor farmers and their lives, with the title literally translating into ‘farmer’s daughter’. Even thematically, the film was ahead of its time because unlike most of the movies in that era that revisited myths and already existing narratives, *Kisan Kanya* delved on real issues. The film could not succeed at the box office due to its limited release owing to the high financial cost of making colour prints then. Regardless, it gave Indians the courage to venture into the realm of colours and just over a decade later, Bollywood made its first technicolour blockbuster, *Aan* in 1952 (TOI entertainment desk, 2025).

Cinema has evolved to be one of the most dominant and expansive sources of expression in human history despite having a history of less than 150 years. The global film and video market was estimated to be at over 287 billion USD in 2023, which was projected to reach almost 550 billion USD by 2033 (Wasay, 2024). Through the massive charm of gossip, fame and glamour, ever increasing popularity and creativity, diversification through TV and OTT platforms and the never ending expanse of movie industries around the world, the figures might as well exceed the projected height.

Introduction to the Topic

Cinema is a medium of art and like any other medium of art like poetry or novels, cinema has its own way of dealing with and giving back to society, which combines as a sum of parts. For instance, if one looks at the trajectory of films that were made in one particular calendar year, they might notice a pattern or type in certain films that may represent concurrent social happenings or political upheavals. On the flipside, it is also very possible that this pattern might not exist and while some films do comment on certain issues, the majority of them might just be movies made for pure entertainment or can appear to have no apparent purpose and were made simply because the director wanted to. What it means is that it is nearly impossible to predict the involvement of cinema in bringing massive changes and showing notable shifts in some vital societal issues like nationalism, feminism, feudalism etc in the span of just one year. However, the concept gets interesting if the purview of time is expanded to decades or ‘eras’. For instance, most film critics would agree that ‘The Golden Age of Hindi Cinema’ was somewhere between 1940s to early 1960s, where unsurprisingly, the themes of national unity, partition, nation building, feminism etc coincided with the melancholy of urban life and distress of the working

class. The period is notable for producing few of the most poignant and representing films of Hindi cinema like *Kismet* (1943), *Awaara* (1951), *Shree 420* (1955), *Pyaasa* (1957), *Kaagaz ke Phool* (1959), *Mother India* (1957), *Mughal-e-Azam* (1960) and many more.

Kismet is credited for succeeding in using the first experimentations in Hindi cinema some of which are depicting a single pregnant lady, an antihero, class conflict and fore-running the ‘lost and found’ archetype in Bollywood that was to be used in countless movies that followed. *Awaara* and *Shree 420* are seen as two of the most defining films of the 1950s. Raj Kapoor, often called ‘The Showman’ of Bollywood, directed and played the protagonist in both of these films. These films were a massive success globally and dealt with the socialist themes and the disillusionment of modern man’s identity in city life, problems of the working class and growing crimes. The films are also cited widely for their popular songs. Likewise, both *Pyaasa* and *Kaagaz ke Phool* were directed and acted-in by Guru Dutt. Guru Dutt’s experiments with melancholy, close-up shots, confluence of poetry, dialogues and music, unmasking of real human behavior and depicting the issues of urban life were very successful and while *Pyaasa* found a spot in Time magazine’s list of 100 greatest movies of all time (Corliss, 2023), *Kaagaz ke Phool* became a critical hit, first Indian film to use CinemaScope technique and is cited as one of the finest, most outstanding self-reflexive Indian films (Sood, 2020) (Samachar Just Click, 2025). *Mother India* is an Indian drama film directed by Mehboob Khan. The title of the movie is an allusion to the all sacrificing and moral ‘*Bharat Mata*’ played exceptionally by Nargis and released a decade after India’s Independence and pivots around the themes of nation building, feudalism criticism, feminism. It was a defining cult classic as well as a box office hit earning around 900,000 USD (at today’s exchange rates). The film was also the first Indian film to be nominated for the Academy Awards in 1958 (Dasgupta, 2025). The last film mentioned in the

list above is *Mughal-e-Azam*. The directive magnum opus of director K. Asif, the movie was a semi-fictional account of a love affair between Salim, the son of emperor Akbar and Anarkali, a court dancer. A period drama, the movie cast big names from the industry like Prithviraj Kapoor (as Akbar), Dilip Kumar (as Salim) and Madhubala (as Anarkali) and became an immense success, crashing the box office and earning the title of being the most earning film for 15 years until the release of *Sholay* in 1975. It was also the most expensive movie made back then and was characterized by the fusion of grand sets, elaborative costumes and class conflict (Nayak, 2025).³

Representative (Political) Films from Every Decade of Bollywood with respect to the Topic

It is an arduous, rather impossible task to choose one or two films from every decade since the 1910s. It is not just because of the sheer volume of movies that have been released or the multitude of filmmaking technique experiments that were being carried around back then. It was also because what movies were reflecting were the rampant changes and events happening in the country's socio-political backdrop. Another reason what makes this selection a Sophie's choice is because while some 'movies' gain popularity which itself attests to their contemporality among masses, some 'films' bring out the less talked, socio-political issues that are representative of the era (It is noteworthy here that in a conversational manner, the difference

³ It is very important to know that although not all the movies mentioned in the paragraph above were immediate successes, they certainly are the cornerstones of the golden age of Hindi cinema and have left a lasting impression on cinema lovers across the world. A few of the movies discussed above will also be discussed politically in the next chapters, as they are also representative of their decades.

between movies and films is that while movies are primarily made to make numbers in the box-office, gain street popularity and providing entertainment, films are generally seen as artistic endeavors on less talked about subjects and usually made in restricted monetary budget). This research has tried to somehow cherry-pick two movies or films from each decade of Indian cinema in a way it thought suitable, starting from the 1910s to the 2010s and 20s. The following paragraphs will discuss the same. It is noteworthy that these movies have been reviewed in a way to not explicitly reveal their plots and discuss them in relation to nationalism, feminism, feudalism and environmentalism, whenever seen fit. Chapter 3.1 will thereby discuss 24 films and 12 decades and so, the analysis will be crisp but thematically sound.

1910s:

1. Raja Harishchandra (1913) Dir. Dada Saheb Phalke

The impact and origins of this film have been elaboratively discussed in the paragraphs above. To talk of its backdrop, the film is set in pre-independence India, when the nation was struggling to find its own identity. With the rising independence movement, the swadeshi movement (1905) and the rise of Gandhi, the quest for freedom was being scripted. The nation was looking for its roots and in the process, saw itself clinging to its ancient culture, myths and legends. Raja Hrishchandra, although not a verifiable figure, does find his presence in Hindu mythology through religious texts like Markandey Purana (Kamakoti, 2017). The movie also utilizes the mythological Indian sage figure of Rishi Vishwamitra and even has an appearance of lord Shiva in the final scene to stop a mishap and praise the king for his choice of duty for the kingdom over his personal interests. Whether or not the king existed is a question to debate but

he has certainly been referred to as a legend and a symbol of unwavering commitment towards truth and nation.

2. Lanka Dahan (1917) Dir. Dada Saheb Phalke

Sharing the backdrop of rising Indian nationalism similar to *Raja Harishchandra*, *Lanka Dahan* belongs to the same foundational era of Indian cinema, known again for cultivating national identity through mythology. It can be seen as an attempt to revisit an incident from *The Ramayana* and give a moral code to a nation distraught under colonial rule and yet to be formed. The central female figure in the film is of Sita and as proclaimed by the *Ramayana*, she is the ultimate symbol of sacrifice, loyalty and undying love. Although Sita might not be considered a conventional feminist figure by most critics today due to her submission to patriarchal norms, her morality and code of conduct was certainly utilized to mobilize the women in the independence movement.

1920s:

1. Bhakta Vidur (1921) Dir. Kanjibhai Rathod

Bhakta Vidur holds a unique, very important accolade in Hindi Cinema and Indian political history; being the first Indian film that was banned, that too by the colonial British government. Every other film in the foundational years of Hindi cinema was using Indian mythology but *Bhakta Vidur* was a breath of fresh air, drenched in nationalistic ethos and rooted in cinematic artistry. It is remembered today for its innovation, a profound concept where it linked the use of mythological figures and the then contemporary political giant of India, Gandhi. To explain, Vidur is a figure from the epic *Mahabharata* known for his wisdom, patience and righteousness. The film portrayed Vidur in the attire of Mahatma Gandhi (even wearing Khadi

and spinning *Charkha*, metaphorizing him as the figure that will guide India to knowledge and freedom. Sensing the unification of masses that could result from this bold and laden metaphor, the colonial censor board famously remarked “We know what you are doing. It’s not Vidur. It’s Gandhi ji. We won’t allow it” (Ministry of Culture, 2025). The banning of the film as early as 1920s itself attests to the power of revolution and cultural change held by cinema.

2. Savkari Pash (1925) Dir. Baburao Painter

Savkari Pash literally translates as the ‘trap of the moneylender’, *Savkar* being the marathi word for Hindi term ‘Sahukar’ meaning moneylender. The film is also anglicized by some as the ‘Indian Shylock’, an allusion to a cruel money lender from Shakespear’s ‘The Merchant of Venice’. A silent film, it is seen as a pioneer of Indian social-realistic cinema and parallel because of its unsanitized and melancholic depiction of the then rampant rural class conflict and the violence of moneylending, an exploitative practice which finds mention in many early Hindi films where rich wealth and land holders lent money to poor landless farmers and charged hefty interests, failing to pay which resulted in ostracization, brutal punishments and sometimes, death. Again, the backdrop of the independence struggle made it but-obvious that the film resonated with nationalistic ideas of unification of masses against colonialization, showcasing the issues of rural India as mainstream.

Women are although shown in the indoor family set-ups, they are not passive and contribute as working units equal to men as members of the same economic system that disregards labour rights and runs on their economic exploitation. Feudalism has been an evil in Indian society for years and the film successfully generates a dialogue against this then dominant and exploitative relationship of farmers and moneylenders.

1930s:

1. *Achhut Kanya* (1937) Dir. Franz Osten and Himanshu Rai

It was one of the earliest and mainstream Hindi films that worked around the rampant but tabooed problem of caste discrimination. '*Achhut Kanya*' literally translates into the untouchable girl. Owing to the subject matter, the film was indeed melancholic for the audience but what it did was that it brought to the forefront, a much-needed discourse to a nation still in its independence struggle, invited the audience to show collectively, the willingness to do away with discrimination based on birth and make the new country a place even untouchables called home. It is important to note that this was the time India was dealing with untouchability as an issue and Mahatma Gandhi had popularized '*Harijan*' as a substitute word for untouchables, literally meaning 'God's people'. Indians began to realize that a reformation was a must and what Gandhi did on political stages and journals, '*Achhut Kanya*' did on the silver screen.

The title had '*Kanya*' in it, meaning a girl and so not doing a gendered reading of the film is criminal. Women have been subjected to patriarchal oppression for thousands of years but being an untouchable woman is 'double marginalization, which means being oppressed both in and out of the house. Although in the early era of Bollywood, a woman's agency was shown usually through a male counterpart, the film is praised highly for bringing the topic to public domain.

2. *Devdas* (1936) Dir. Pramathesh Chandra Barua

Devdas is often referred to as a pioneer of novel adaptations in Bollywood. Adapted from Sarat Chandra Chattopadhyay's 1917 novel of the same name, the story has been told and re-told by different directors and through different approaches, the most famous ones being *Devdas* (2002) and *Dev D* (2009). The main themes built upon by the film are fragile morals of the

society, the treatment of courtesans or *Tawaifs* and class anxieties. The story type usually utilizes a melancholic-alcoholic male protagonist and two women, one of a high caste and another a *Tawaif*.

The film brings forth the debate of what is a respectable woman and how respectable in reality are the high class *Zamindar* men who come and see them. The narrative blurs the binaries between ‘good’ and ‘bad’ women, giving courtesans a respectful stance in the society, against the wishes of the bourgeoisie.

Ecologically, the story depicts villages and cities as dichotomies; villages being where moral codes are still somewhat in-tact and cities becoming the sites of anonymity and dissolution.

1940s:

1. Neecha Nagar (1946) Dir. Chetan Anand

Neecha Nagar is seen as an explicit case of the combination of social-realist cinema. It was adopted from a 1920 Russian play ‘The Lower Depths’ written by famous novelist Maxim Gorky. It depicted a revolution by city inhabitants against an autocratic mayor when people died of water contamination. Setting a tone for anti-imperialism and anti-capitalism, the film worked around a class stratification allegory and laid bare the widespread urban corruption. In the era of upsurging national pride just before independence, it proclaimed that true freedom would not be possible to attain without diluting class boundaries.

It also presented a case about how women’s labour, sexuality, and reproductive functions are weaponized by market and patriarchal forces against them. The environment in the film has

been shown as a decaying mass of slums and drains, a place certainly unfit for dreaming of freedom and representing the decay of society due to class violence.

It became a critical success and won the Grand Prix award at the 1946 Cannes film festival. Moreover, it is the only Indian film to ever win the prestigious Palme d'or award. The film even earns the title of being the first Indian art film and rightly so because of its unique features like a sequence that interpreted a famous poem by Alexander Pushkin and launched famous Indian musician Pt. Ravi Shankar's career as a music director. Not only was it praised by legendary filmmakers like Satyajit Ray and Mrinal Sen, it even pleased Lord Mountbatten who wished to see it being released nation-wide (Gupta, 2021).

2. Mahal (1949) Dir. Kamal Amrohi

Mahal is cited popularly as Bollywood's first successful experiment with the genres of gothic and horror. The grand sets of abandoned palaces and haunted patriarchal legacies hint towards a decline of the old social orders, making the haunted mansion not just a set for plot development but also a residue of the declining age of feudalism. The song "*Aayega Aanevala*" represents an inevitable shift in the history where equality would exist and patriarchal Zamindaris will perish. The decaying Haveli is a sign of it.

The female figure in the film is of a woman who haunts the house. Her presence on the screen is all pervasive, unafraid of the male authority. She represents female autonomous desire and resistance against patriarchal codes and morals. The spooky environment adds to the aura of film, making it a benchmark in cinematic experiments.

1950s:

1. Shree 420 (1955) Dir. Raj Kapoor⁴

Shree 420 is an interesting title. One interpretation of it can be that *Shree* means wealth in Sanskrit and 420 refers to the IPC⁵ section 420 that deals with laws on cheating and financial dishonesty, mirroring the theme of this film. Released in the decade following Indian independence, the film gives a moral lesson to the audience, showcasing that the world of corruption leads but to ruins. The newly built nation needs to function on honesty.

The film presents a sharp critique of moral corruption. Its Charlie-Chaplinesque pathos and very popular song “*Mera Joota Hai Japani*” tells Indians to take arts and culture from the world but never forget your roots. The song also suggests that it is about time that Indians will become globalized. That does not suggest indolence towards the homeland. The film ridicules the new-rich and amoral opportunists.

From a feminist perspective, women serve mostly as the moral interlocutors in the film, tied with men in their pursuit to moral reformation but seldom having an autonomous political reaction. The city landscape works as an ecological metaphor for moral pollution and nostalgia for the simpler times.

2. Mother India (1957) Dir. Mehboob Khan⁶

Mother India occupies a grand stature in Indian cinema and its political motifs. It highlights the themes of self-reliance, hard work and undeniable contribution of women in nation building. The title of the film does its part in linking the nation and family with the dual imagery of ‘*Bharat Mata*’.

⁴ Already discussed briefly in Chapter 2

⁵ Indian Penal Code

⁶ Already discussed briefly in chapter 2

The protagonist, Radha is shown as an unwavering persona possessing an almost mythological quality of maintaining just and morally correct stance despite hardships on all fronts of life. The all sacrificing and giving woman is critiqued by some film critics today for submitting to male order but when seen in the context of a single, poor mother trying to survive yet not falling to vices, *Mother India* offers one of the first sturdy woman characters in Hindi cinema.

The exploitative *Zamindari* system and the murder of a cruel moneylender can be seen mirroring the new India's rebellion against exploitative British past and conquering it with virtues and dedication to truth or sometimes, a hard fought rebellion. The final scene of the film stays with the audience and they are amazed by the peasant-woman protagonist's clear stance on ethical choice between a moral and personal dilemma.

The agrarian symbols of tilling, fertility and collaborative farming are seen today as the reformatory symbols of a young nation in making.

1960s:

1. *Bandini* (1963) Dir. Bimal Roy

Adopted from a Bengali novel, *Bandini* is considered a radical film that negotiates between the personal and the political imprisonment of a woman's identity, literally and metaphorically. The film is set in 1930s Bengal where the protagonist, a lady, is imprisoned for a murder. She becomes a symbol and her cell, a microcosm of the nation under British rule; wounded, yet seeking moral renewal. The use of natural lighting, long silences and almost no melodramatic dialogues present a realistic imagery which paves way for the ethical awakening of the nation asleep in deep stupor.

The film does not show the protagonist as a victim, rather an emotionally complex being who resists idealization, also showcasing the newly emerging post-colonial feminist movement of the 1960s and 70s. The film also metaphorizes the restrictions of male authority that continues to imprison women, regardless of political freedom.

The use of Bengal's natural imagery through rivers, fisherman boats and open skies show a gentle path of redemption for the protagonist, women and in the process, the country itself. *Bandini* was both a commercial and critical success.

2. Jewel Thief (1967) Dir, Vijay Anand

Jewel Thief is seen today as an attempt to modernize Hindi cinema, as early as late 1960s. Dealing in jewels, espionage and extremely popular songs, the film hides the allegory of duplicacy and moral corruption in the still young India beneath its glamorous surface. The film shows clear inspiration from the James Bond thrillers and Alfred Hitchcock's psychological mysteries, connecting Indian music and identity with global cinema. Disguise, changing identities and a dark air of crime beneath give the film its flavour and also reflects the mimicking Indian minds with respect to the global cosmopolitan, negotiating between real and fake, authentic and artificial. The protagonist's journey from disguise and cheating to ultimately being loyal to morality affirms the then emerging form of nationalism that reconciled globalization with virtue.

On the question of women, the film depicts the urban, self aware women who seem liberated on the surface but are still structurally confined. Although still seen as the objects of male gaze, the central woman figure in the film represents women asserting their presence and negotiating their right place with the society, bit by bit.

1970s:

1. *Pakeezah* (1972) Dir. Kamal Amrohi

The title of this film is taken from Urdu meaning 'pure'. *Pakeezah* is a gem of Indian cinema, providing some of one of the most delicate reflections and meditations on the issue of gender, love and cultural decay, presented through the soft poetry, grand sets, detailed heavy costumes and other intricacies of the *tawaifs*. The lead character is played by Meena Kumari, whose personal life eerily mirrored her character of Sahibjaan.

Politically, the film seems to mourn the gradually deteriorating cultural value of the Indo-Islamic culture post partition. This was slowly affecting the arts, poetry, music, dance and refined mannerisms of the courtesans and rendering them as mere prostitutes. This is shown beautifully by the film through the character of Sahibjaan who is almost worshipped for her beauty and manners and yet, is unable to dictate her own life and is almost voiceless. simultaneously worshipped and stigmatized, embodies the paradox of being visible yet voiceless. The glamorous dresses, Nawabi manners and grand halls of the *Kothas* hide under them, the women that were once free.

Pakeezah's artificial rivers, moonlit courtyards and perfumed chambers evoke an aesthetic environment, a world which now survives only in memory, a lost realm of arts, culture, and music. The film should be seen and celebrated as the last monument of a civilization, slowly turning to myth.

2. *Garam Hawa* (1974) Dir. M.S. Sathyu

Garam Hawa is undoubtedly one of the finest and most compassionate studies on the wounds of partition, searching for a distraught identity through the struggles of a Muslim family in north India. The early 1970s was a turbulent time in India history when the debates around

secularism and state power grew. Amidst this, the film tells the story of Salim Mirza who refuses to migrate to Pakistan like many of his family members have and endures the increasing social and economic pressures in this process that keeps checking his patriotism. No use of melodrama, real life locations and ground struggles give the nationalistic debate a true fervor, a practice rooted in endurance and integrity.

The film also amplifies the struggle of women and depicts that in the times of crisis, women bear the worst weight. Displacement and rejection automatically engulf them. A suicide by one of the female characters in the film presents a devastating reality about how male honour and communal politics hold zero regard for a woman in love.

The declining wealth of the Mirzas, dusty streets and the ruins of Havelis became metaphors for concurrent socio-politics and communal harmony.

1980s:

1. Aakrosh (1980) Dir. Govind Nihlani

Aakrosh is a masterpiece of parallel Indian cinema, with its screenplay written by the popular Marathi playwright Vijay Tendulkar. It lays bare the moral depletion in post-independence India, amidst the facade of the 'largest democracy'. The film surprised the Indian audience because of its upfront confrontation of caste oppression, police brutality and judicial corruption. Completely devoid of melodrama, the film shows how the promise of freedom has failed the lower stratas of society. The deafening suffering of the tribal protagonist Bhiku contrasts with the numbness of the entire country's moral conscience.

A feminist reading of *Aakrosh* studies the visual sexual violence as a systemic practice against Dalit women and not just an isolated rape of Bhiku's wife. The omnipresent muteness of

her resonates with the silence of those in power. It also shows how patriarchy uses caste domination as an instrument of oppression. The film also lays bare the reality of still persistent feudalism in independent India landlords, police and bureaucrats benefit from each other in a continuous cycle of exploiting lower caste people. In the final scene of the film, Bhiku's violent outburst becomes a symbolic revolt, a rather self harming act which at least gives him a vent and symbolises the tragic end of moral values.

The use of desolated, heated and barren landscape as the setting of the film represents a society, drained of growth and comfort.

2. Mandi (1983) Dir. Shyam Benegal

Mandi (meaning marketplace) was adapted from an Urdu short story '*Aanandi*' written by Ghulam Abbas. The major broad themes around which the film operates are moral hypocrisy, forbidden love and political manipulation as a tool to subjugate women. The brothel is used both as a setting and metaphor for the moral paradoxes in urban India. Through humor and sometimes chaos, the film critiques how bureaucracy and political nationalism works through demonizing certain sections and their exclusion. The city elites and self-proclaimed women's rights activists carry out rallies for banning brothels, while everyone privately consumes its pleasures. In doing so, *Mandi* exposes how bourgeois puts the burden of moral responsibility only on the weaker sections of society, those who practice 'immorality' to sustain themselves.

In feminist interpretations, the brothel serves as an intimate indoor space where female creativity and affection generate the feeling of a community instead of degradation. *Mandi* refuses to show these women as sex objects, imparting them with humour, complex ideals, dream and art of music. Women's bodies are still seen as transactional commodities by the elites, the politicians, landowners, and businessmen. Although (Shabana Azmi), the brothel's matriarch

tries to reverse this hierarchy through love, care and development of female structure, she is ultimately made to leave the brothel, showcasing the hard reality where ultimately, everyone is on their own.

Through the unfulfilled and tragic love affair of Zeenat (Smita Patil) and Sushil (Aditya Bhattacharya), it is shown that love can transcend class structures but the core of women like Zeenat is so much ruined by the society that it is impossible for her to stay happy without the guilt associated with the pleasures.

1990s:

1. Fire (1996) Dir. Deepa Mehta

Although not a Hindi film per say, Fire deserves a spot in the list for its bold themes and deeply Indian sensibilities. It is a bold and furious take on female sexuality and autonomy, which transforms a middle class hindu household into a site of a lesbian relationship. The two women characters, Radha and Sita, get closer to each other because their husbands ignore them, through celibacy or mistresses. The names of these women allude to the Hindu mythological women who, as per the views of many feminist critics, endured hardships in their love lives too.

The film sets out to expose the cisgendered-heteronormative ideology that controls a woman's pleasure by denial of their queer identities. The film stands out for its treatment of female desire and agency. Towards the end of the film, both the women dare to leave their husbands, embrace in the pouring rain and await a future which is uncertain but the one in which they are together.

2. Satya (1998) Dir. Ram Gopal Verma

Satya totally redefined the purview of Hindi cinema, garnering great success as a crime-thriller which thrives in the ‘Mumbai noir’, a genre that fuses the semi-fictional gangster narratives of underworld in Mumbai with the post liberalisation anxieties. Mumbai is a city characterized by a huge financial divide and a place that gives shelter to everyone; migrants, criminals and even struggling actors. The film exposes the real state of economic progress post LPG (Liberalization, Privatization, Globalization) policies of the early 1990s by showing how the lower classes survive within a set power structure of systemic exclusion, where legality blurs into survival strategies. What makes *Satya* unique is that it does not add unnecessary glamour to the underworld like many other movies; it uses this pretext to hint towards urban alienation, morality, violence and desire.

Environmentally, the over-crowded chawls, dim lit streets and suffocating interior suggest an ecological claustrophobia where the city itself becomes a symbol of decaying morality.

2000s:

1. Gangajal (2003) Dir Prakash Jha

Gangajal is a burning hot, semi-fictional political drama which closely observes the intersection of law, corruption and power in rural Bihar, depicted through Tejpur. Amit Kumar (Ajay Devgan) is an honest police officer on duty to ‘clear’ Tejpur of political corruption and intertwined violence. The real question raised by the movie is that what is the role of governments in stopping political violence and is it able to do justice to the duty? ‘*Gangajal*’ refers to the water of the Ganga river, sacred to many Indians, yet polluted in many places. The

film critically examines the role of police in controlling crime wherein they are supposed to be guardians of order but have to work alongside the nexus of politicians and dirty politics. The film, through its title suggests that the system is so rotten to the core that a ritualistic cleansing might not suffice; deep and grassroot cleaning needs to be done to rid the system of many termites that eat it from the inside gradually, rendering it hollow.

The environmentally profound imagery is used by Jha to represent the dichotomy, on one hand where Ganga river provides life and calm to the northern belt of India, 'gangajal' in the movie also alludes to the infamous political blindings which happened in the 1990s Bihar, where multiple men were detained by the police without proper paperwork and were blinded using acid that was poured in their eyes.

2. Rock on! (2008) Dir. Abhishek Kapoor

On the surface, *Rock On!* is a light-hearted Hindi musical story of a friend musician group that rekindles their friendship after a misunderstanding broke them apart but beneath the surface, it is beyond just music and friendship. It captures the struggles of a post liberalization generation of urban Indian kids enchanted by the charms of modern lifestyle but are stuck between aspirations and disillusionment it brings along. It presents a fusion of identities, global tastes and an India which is getting comfortable with globalization, where music transcends geographical boundaries.

Although women occupy the backseat in the narrative, they work like anchor figures, holding the fragmented dreams of men and giving them an emotional recluse. The film exposes male dominated gender matrix in India where even though global music has been adopted, the value of female labour stays invisible and becomes an unsung hero in male pursuit to freedom.

2010s:

1. *Uri: The Surgical Strike* (2019) Dir. Aditya Dhar

Uri is a sector in the Baramulla district of Kashmir. The movie is a dramatization of the retaliation by the Indian armed forces post the devastating 2016 Pathankot attack. The film banks upon the new-found rage in Indian youth against Pakistan and the various terror group activities, a form of neo-nationalism where one nation sees itself superior over another and perceives itself in contrast to the other. The film evokes and amplifies a collective national identity predicated on military strength, sacrifice and revenge. In the post-2014 domestic political context (with heightened nationalism in public discourse), *Uri* becomes both entertainment and nationalist spectacle.

The movie did a business of over 300 crore rupees worldwide and was rewarded with various accolades like the national film awards for leading male actor and the director. It was also warmly received by the countrymen who seemed to have seen a future image of India as “*Yeh naya Bharat hai. Ye ghar mein ghus kar maarega*” as proclaimed multiple times by the Indian Prime minister himself (NI Desk, 2025), stating that unlike the conventional peaceful image of India, the ‘new India’ will be violent and not merciful towards its enemies.

2. *Pink* (2016) Dir: Aniruddha Roy Chowdhury

‘*Pink*’ is seen as a contemporary milestone in popular Hindi cinema, an explicitly feminist narrative that criticizes gender justice and brings consent in the discussion. Set in Delhi, also referred to by some as the crime capital of India, the film traces the becoming of a private act of sexual aggression into a full-fledged national moral inquiry, navigating the reality of gender equality within the legal framework of rights and equality. In ‘*Pink*’, the theme of nationalism is seen through the lens of courtroom and law. By repeatedly bringing in consent and

the 'No means No' narrative, the film launches a civic inquiry too, implying that women's rights are and should be a dinner table conversation in every house and not just in the courtroom, ranging from dresses to morality to sexuality.

The film also dethrones the male saviour archetype; even though Amitabh Bachchan's male lawyer character helps the case, he is an accomplice not a hero. Yet again, respecting the serious theme, 'Pink' refuses to enter melodrama and just like its title, does not deny that pink is a colour liked by women, but embraces it.

2020s:

1. *Bulbul* (2020) Dir. Anvita Dutt

Bulbul is a type of bird commonly found in India known for its melodious voice and red undertail, both of which are severely important in context of the film. The film presents a neo-gothic tale that uses the Indian motif of *chudail* or a witch as a vent to address feminist concerns and uses myths to counter patriarchy. The intermixing of red and other vibrant colour palettes with music that generates a gothic environment in rural Bengal goes very well with the VFX and cinematography techniques used in the film.

The film invokes a late 19th century Bengal mixed with rural ethos and coming of modernity to complicate the issue of nationalism where the viewers go back in time to see how patriarchy and brutality on women coincided with *Zamindar* wealth, Havelis of *Thakurs* and national identity as if to make a statement that how these preserve male dominance and that a nation which tolerates domestic terrorism on its own citizens can never be fully independent.

Feminism is the most explicit theme in the film. It turns the table by flipping the stereotypical narrative of 'evil witch' by making her a monstrous feminine figure, broken by

patriarchy yet standing her ground for justice. It invokes trauma visually and narratively and deals with many crucial themes like child marriage, female rage and sexual violence. The depiction of fierce, suppressed rage is also a show of catharsis, where the justice might not be completely served but a vent has been provided to let out.

The deep-dark forests at late night, the symbol of a bulbul bird and quiet havelis serve as the gothic environment of the film and complements its themes.

2. Animal (2023) Dir. Sandeep Reddy Vanga

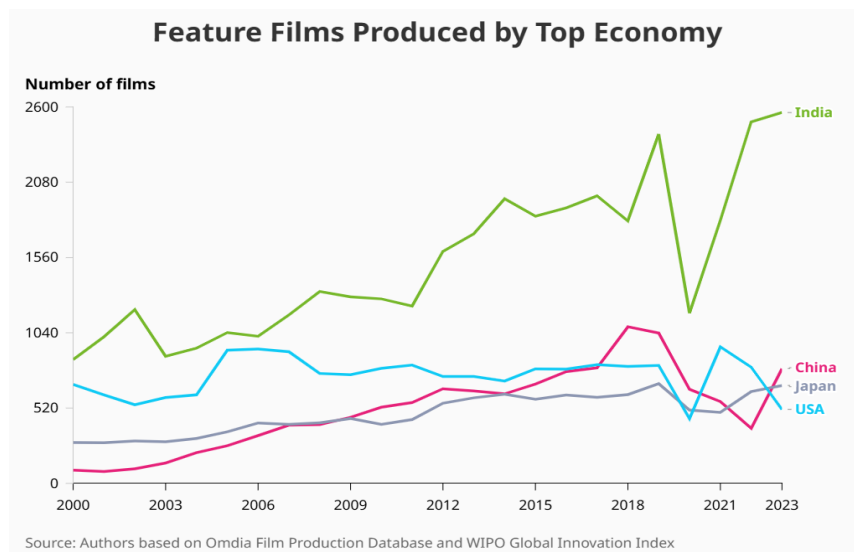
Probably the most controversial choice in this list, the movie is important to include opposite to '*Bulbbul*' to prove the same point; the need of feminism in movies. '*Animal*' presents a male utopia, a hyper-masculine reality where women's rights and opinions take a backseat. The actions of the violent and vengeful male protagonist are framed as overly exaggerated virtues of loyalty to blood, brotherhood and familial honour. The 'Alpha male' narrative adopted by the movie is deeply troubling to the society as it is not the mere representation of that category of men that actually exist; it shows that stereotype to be cool, glorifying violent and misogynistic behaviours that can impact the minds of young men and make them act 'cooler'.

Women are just used as props for furthering the plot, as side characters in this male revenge saga. The film also echoes feudal dynamics of exaggerated loyalty, patriarchal inheritance, violence and blood and vengeance, elements that further fuel male superiority and view a woman as a territory to be conquered.

It is noteworthy that despite its clear and overt depiction (and celebration) of domestic violence, sexual infidelity, blood, gang wars and hyper masculinity, the movie became one of the highest grossing movies of Bollywood, earning over 900 crore rupees globally (Livemint, 2024), probably the reason and critique of it being included in this list. This shows that unfortunately,

the grassroots of Indian audiences is still as Satyajit Ray once proclaimed, “fairly backward, unsophisticated” (HT entertainment desk, 2023).

Conclusion



After going through chapter 3, it becomes easy to trace the trajectory of political upheavals in India; whether it is the pre independence strife for ancient morals, rules and codes to live life or post independence quest for lost identity and communal wounds of partition, or contemporary ethos of becoming a world leader and a strong, developed military power, India has come a long, though not a smooth way and so has the Hindi cinema. This change, film by film and character by character can also be traced through a brief trajectory of female characters mentioned in the study.

From an obedient yet moral and steadfast protagonist Sita in *Lanka Dehan*, women grew on and started participating and supporting in India's nation building process and financially

assisting men, bearing the burden within the home and outside it in *Savkari Pash*. From there, the growth has been steady with the ghost in *Mahal* registering her space, occupying the ruins of a patriarchal setting and gaining more on-screen time as an autonomous figure. Here, gothic becomes a device for emancipation. Towards the 50s, as the nation was close to attaining independence, women were given a deity-like structure as in ‘Mother India’, a sacrificing and non selfish figure. This deity-fication is a problem in the long run because on the ground and practical level, women were still very dominated by men in all aspects. In the mid 60s, the situation changed gradually.

In the country’s politics, Indira Gandhi became the first Indian woman prime minister in 1966 (Britannica editors, 2025) and just three years prior to it, *Bandini* was released which rejected the deity-fication and depicted that women are human beings too, very capable of both crime and redemption like their male counterparts. Unlike the sanitized Radha of Mother India, Kalyani from *Bandini* shows signs of rebellion. A more confident and urban image of a woman appears in jewel thief, still affected by male gaze but trying to find a way out. From there, the ride is more difficult, sometimes still being the victims of communal politics and male gaze like in ‘*Pakeezah*’, sometimes taking control of their bodies like in ‘*Fire*’, sometimes healing in their own ways from the wound of oppression in ‘*Bulbbul*’ and sometimes again being taken centuries ago by films like ‘*Animal*’. The reason why ‘*Animal*’ has been chosen opposite to ‘*Bulbbul*’ from the 2020s is because interestingly enough, they were released 3 years apart, being absolutely opposite in themes and sparking opposite reactions.

To sum up the impact of Cinema in India, it can be said that whether it is setting unreal expectations from cliché love stories, giving prototypes of men and women in love, adding to cultural linguistic diversity through dialogues and catchphrases and creating stereotypical

archetypes of rich aunties, young adults old uncles and basically every kind of person and profession we see around or generating political turmoil, representing the marginal groups, giving a voice to the misrepresented and ignored groups and satirizing establishments and dogmas, cinema in India has been all pervasive and become a part of the identity of the country itself. Afterall, it is Bollywood that produces the most number of movies in the world, with a popular saying that there's a new addition to the list every Friday, although that is an understatement.

(Hancock et. al., 2025)

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